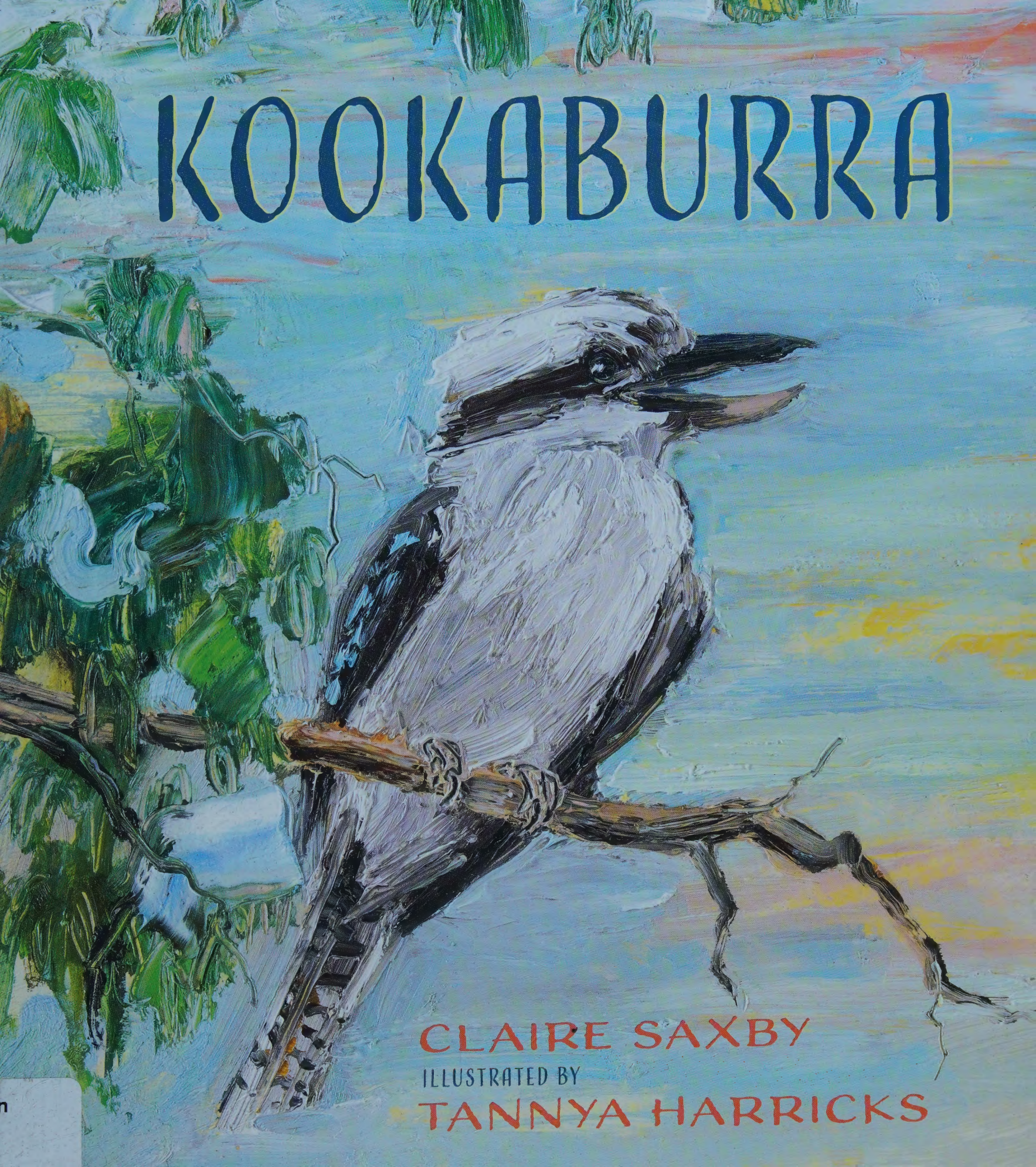


KOOKABURRA



CLAIRE SAXBY

ILLUSTRATED BY

TANNYA HARRICKS





Abigail Rae, this one is for you.

CS

To Poppy, Joey, Freddie, and Lucy

TH

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Illustrations copyright © 2020 by Tannya Harricks

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First US edition 2021

Library of Congress Catalog Card Number pending
ISBN 978-1-5362-1519-9

TLF 26 25 24 23 22 21
10 9 8 7 6 5 4 3 2 1

Printed in Dongguan, Guangdong, China

This book was typeset in Briosio Pro and Gararond.
The illustrations were done in oil.

Candlewick Press
99 Dover Street
Somerville, Massachusetts 02144

www.candlewick.com



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In the crinkled shadows,
night dwellers yawn,
day creatures stretch,
and Kookaburra laughs.

In a line on a limb with her mate and
three young, she leads a sunrise chorus.

Kook-kook-kook.

Kak-kak-kak.





When they are done, her family members leave,
each on a solo search for food.

Kookaburra stays.

She tips her head to the side,
watches,
watches,
straightens,
watches.



Swoops!



Kookaburras have very good eyesight, and tipping their head to the side helps them spot their prey more easily.



Her mate appears, a skink in his beak.
It is a gift for Kookaburra as they
approach a new nesting season.

An artistic illustration of two kookaburras in flight. The birds are depicted with white plumage on their heads and chests, and dark brown or black feathers on their wings and backs. Their wings are spread wide, showing the intricate structure of the feathers. The background is a soft, light blue sky. In the bottom left corner, there is a glimpse of green foliage, possibly eucalyptus leaves, rendered in a painterly style. The overall composition is dynamic, capturing the birds in mid-flight.

Together they go nest hunting.

She *kookas*,

he *kookas*,

soft murmurings for their ears only.

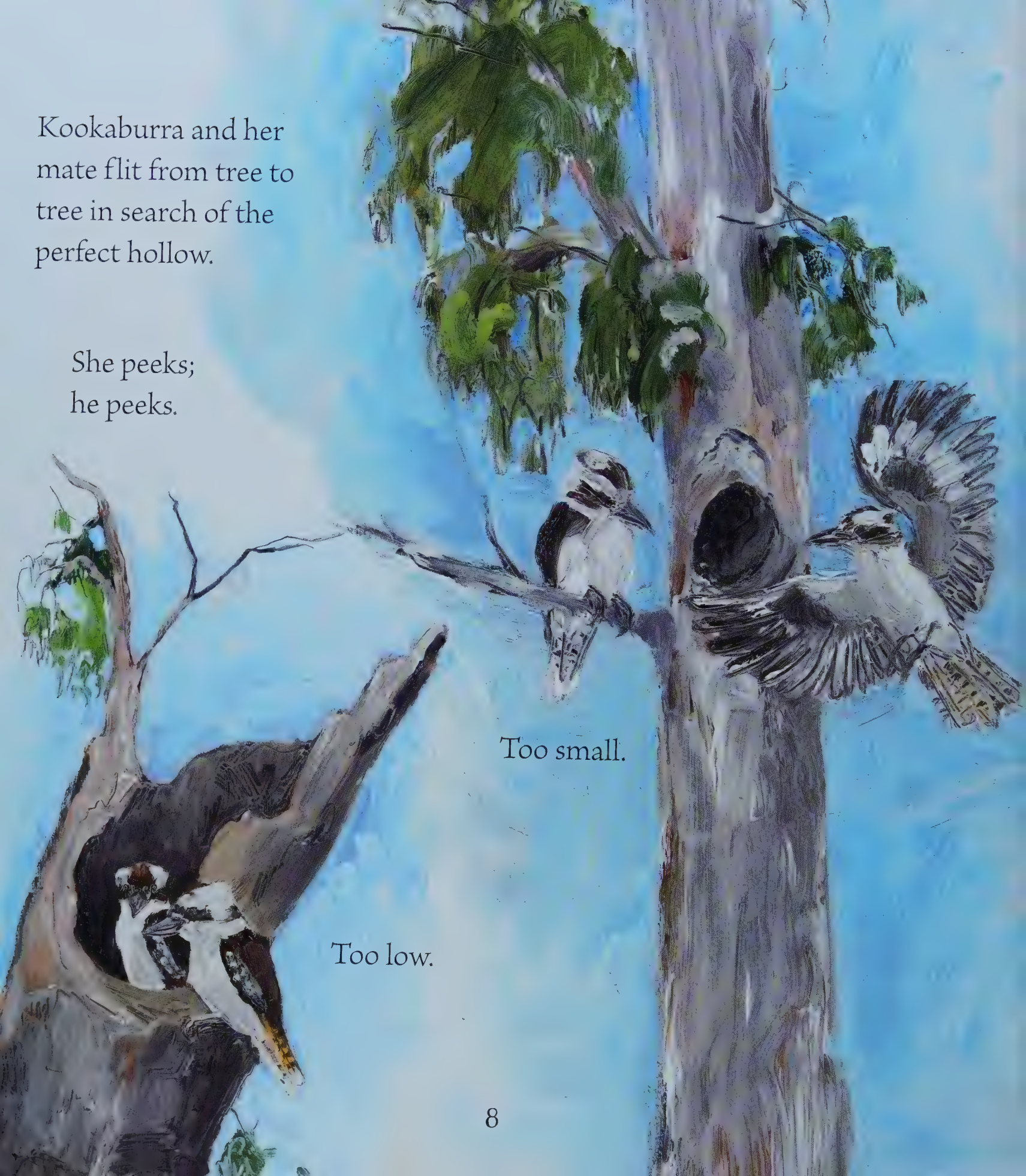
*Kookaburras mostly partner
for life but still court before
each nesting season.*

Kookaburra and her
mate flit from tree to
tree in search of the
perfect hollow.

She peeks;
he peeks.

Too small.

Too low.



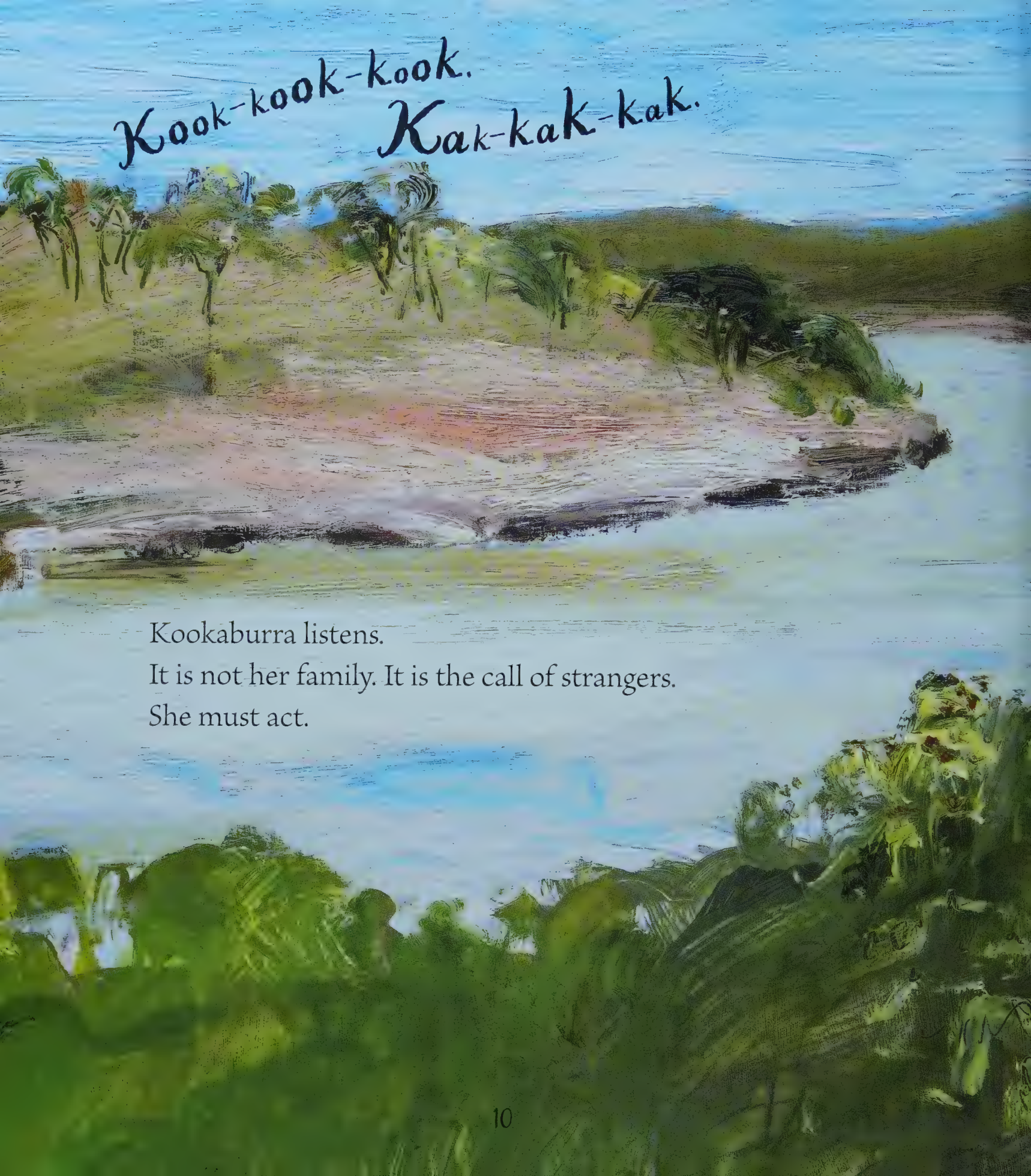


Not right.

They return to
a familiar tree
hollow—last
year's nest.

It's perfect.

*Each year, pairs look for
a new nesting hollow,
but 50 percent of the
time, they use the nest
from the previous year.*



*Kook-kook-kook.
Kak-kak-kak.*

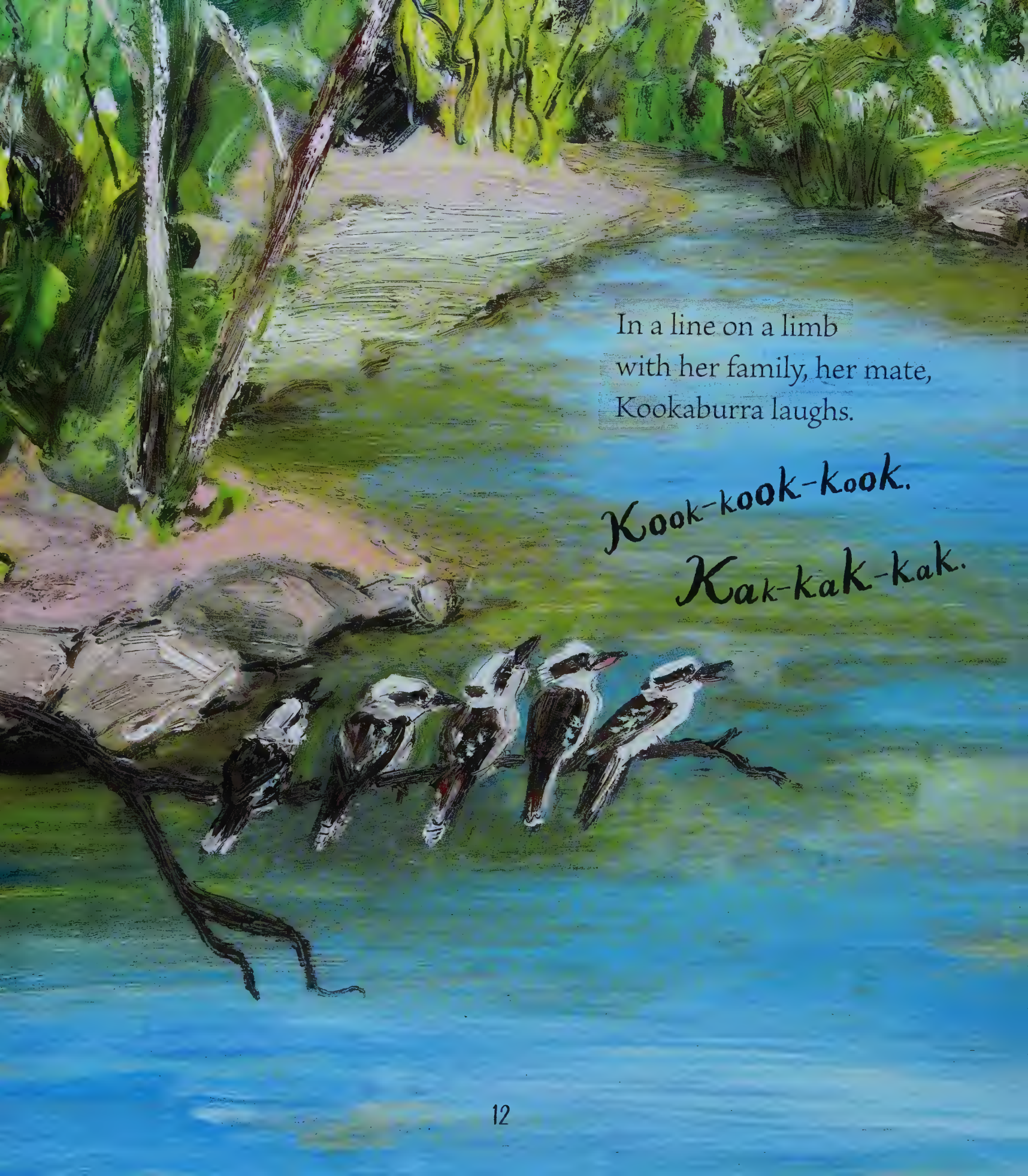
Kookaburra listens.

It is not her family. It is the call of strangers.

She must act.

An artistic painting of a Kookaburra in a natural setting. The bird is the central focus, shown in profile with its head turned slightly towards the viewer. It has a white face with a dark stripe through the eye, a dark beak, and a dark crest. Its body is white with dark, mottled patterns. The background is a soft, painterly landscape with green foliage on the right and a body of water or a path leading into the distance. The overall style is impressionistic with visible brushstrokes.

*Kookaburra families
have established
territories and
defend their borders.*



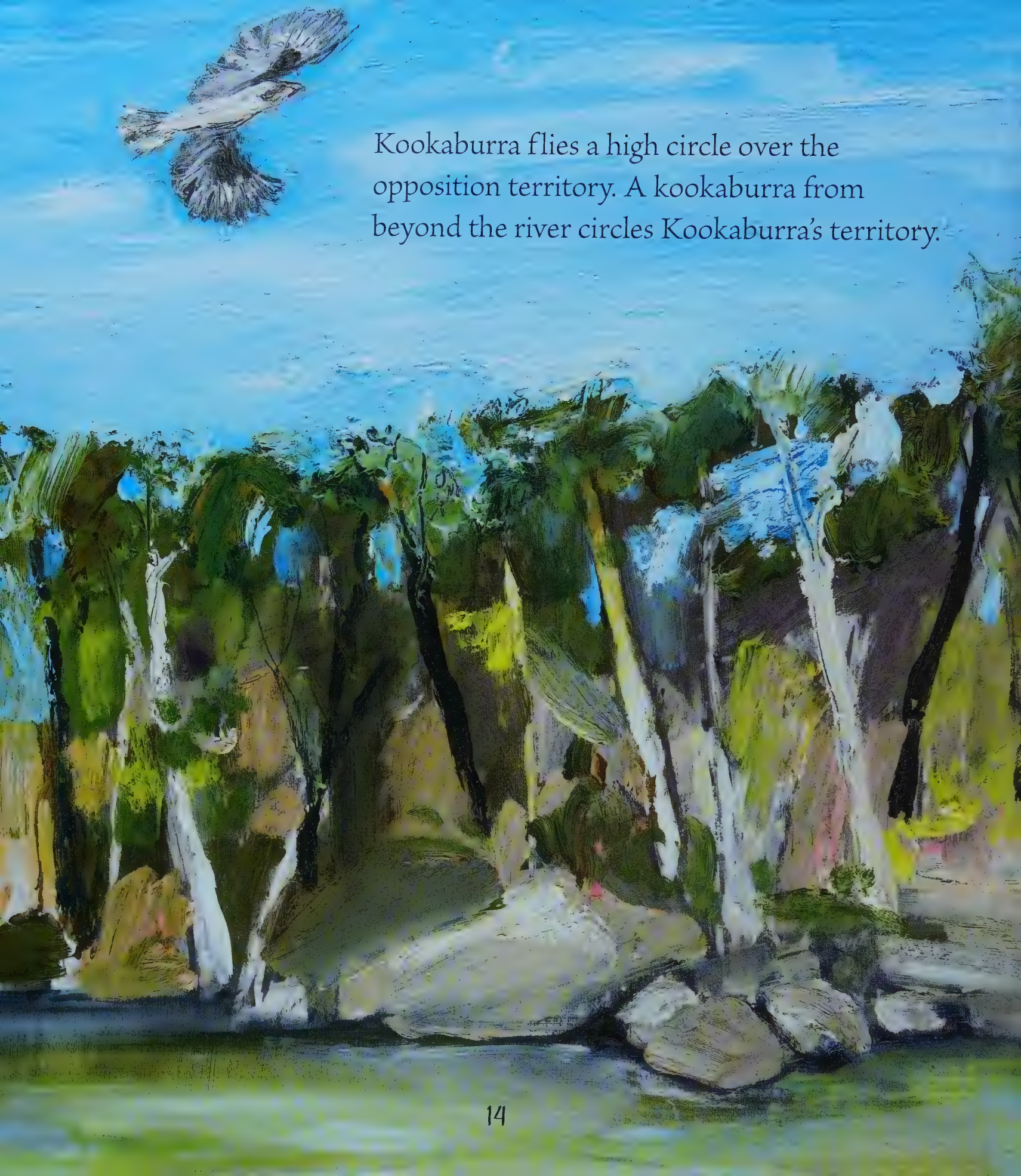
In a line on a limb
with her family, her mate,
Kookaburra laughs.

*Kook-kook-kook.
Kak-kak-kak.*



Across the river that separates them,
the other family laughs again.
It is a challenge.

*Territorial displays become more
frequent as nesting season approaches.*

A kookaburra is shown in flight in the upper left corner, its wings spread wide against a clear blue sky. Below the bird, a dense forest of tall, slender trees with green foliage stretches across the middle ground. In the foreground, a river flows, its surface reflecting the light. Large, light-colored rocks are scattered along the riverbank. The overall scene is a naturalistic depiction of a kookaburra's habitat.

Kookaburra flies a high circle over the
opposition territory. A kookaburra from
beyond the river circles Kookaburra's territory.

Kookaburra's mate flies toward a tree, flares his feathers
at the mouth of a hollow, then returns to sit alongside her.

A neighbor mirrors his flight.



*These rituals confirm territory boundaries
without the need for fighting. It's as if
the birds are saying, "This is our place."*



The songs dwindle.
Their boundaries are safe for now.
And it's lunchtime.
Again, Kookaburra sits alone.
There will be snails here.

She watches and swoops.

Thwack,

thwack—she cracks a shell and swallows.

She returns to the nesting hollow to check that it is ready for the eggs that she will soon lay.



Female kookaburras are larger than males and need more food, particularly in preparation for laying eggs.

Her mate is nearby. He comes
and goes, bringing a cricket, then a worm.

She *kookas*.

He *kookas*.

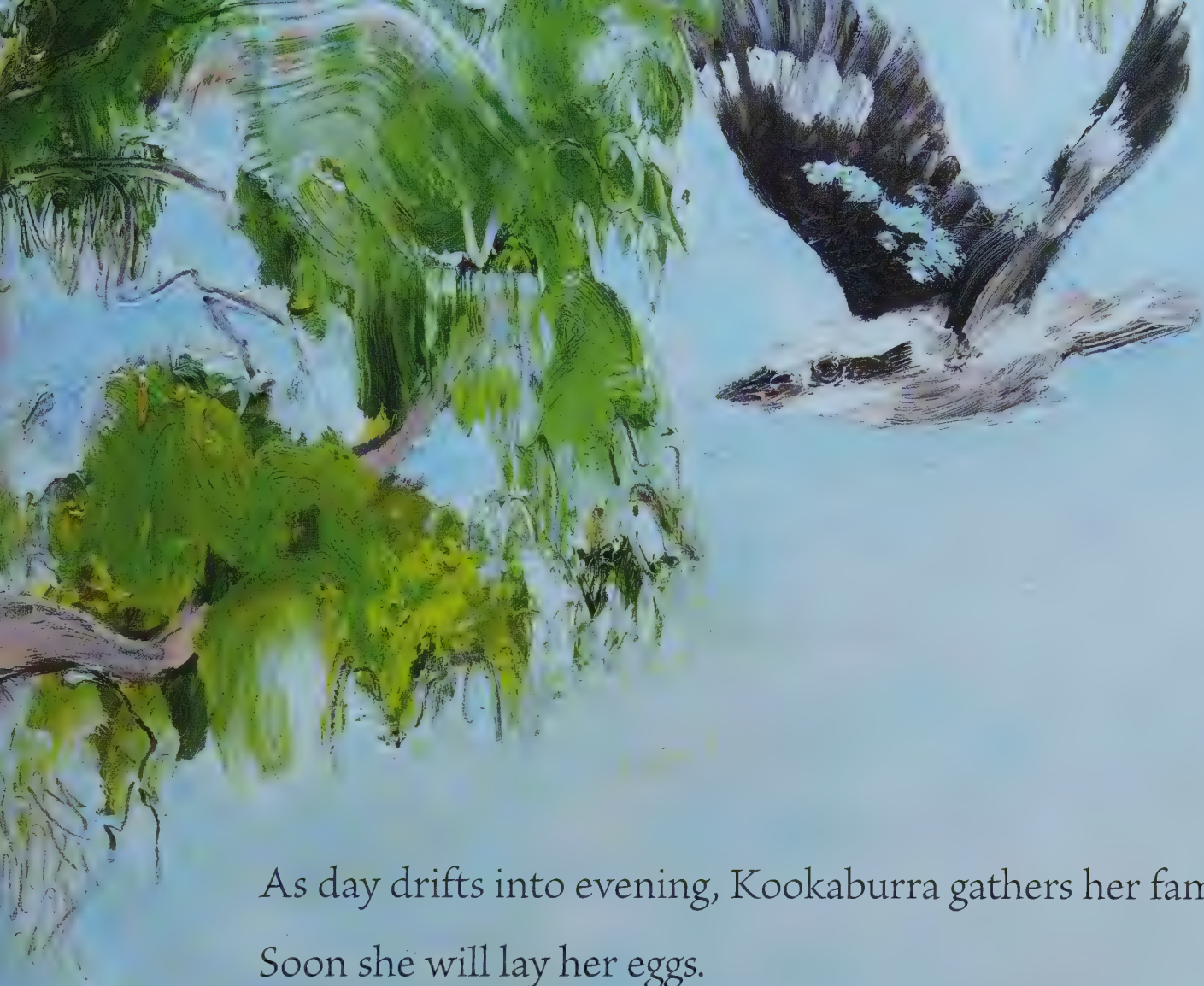


A single kookaburra appears. This is an invasion.
Kookaburra's family attacks, fast and fierce.
The invader flees.
Nesting is a tense time, and everyone works
together to make sure it goes well.



Single kookaburras sometimes invade other territories in search of a mate. Unless one of a pair has died, there is no vacancy.



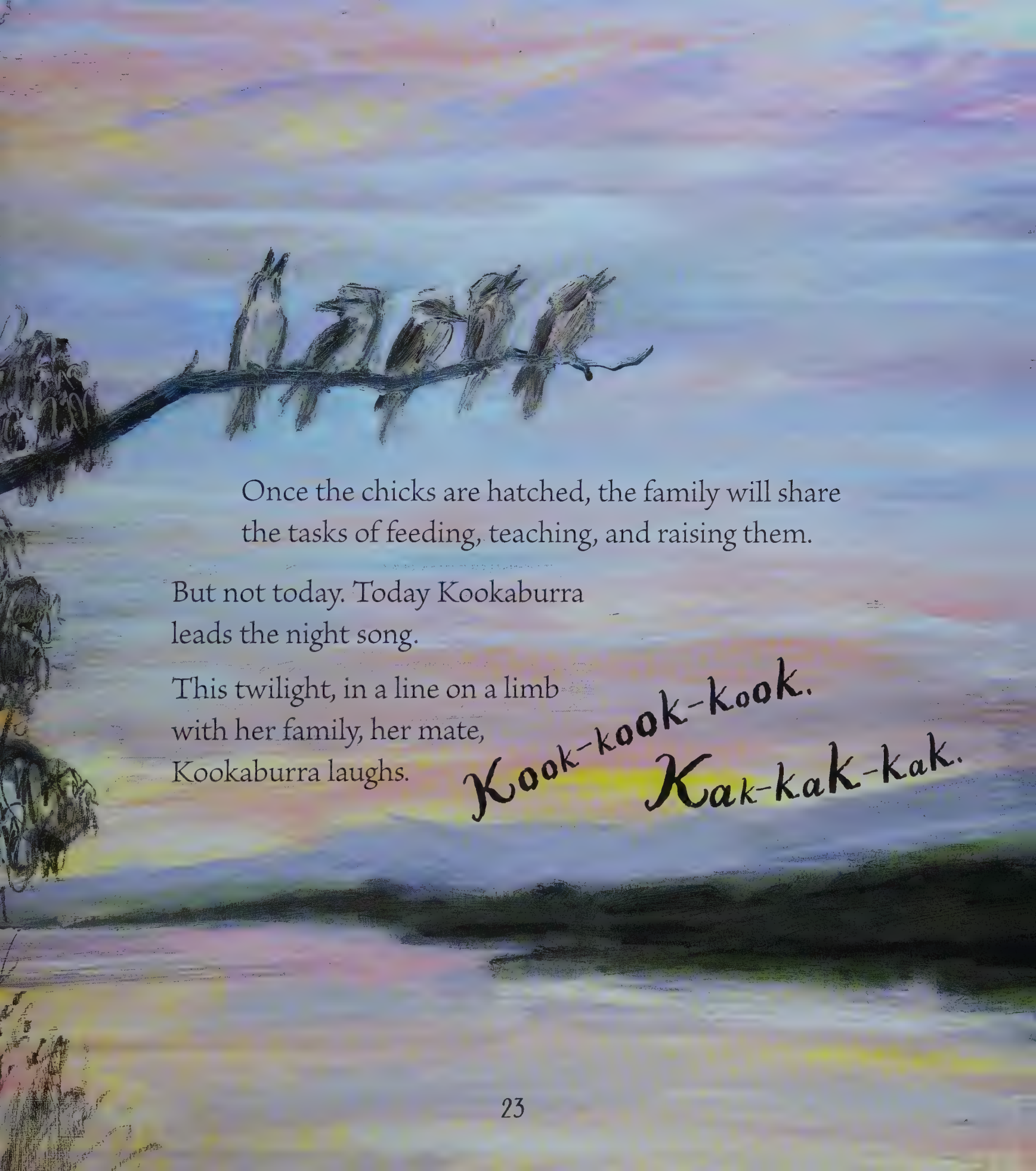


As day drifts into evening, Kookaburra gathers her family.
Soon she will lay her eggs.

While she sits on them, Kookaburra's family will bring food,
protect their territory, and sometimes share the nesting.

*Kookaburras usually lay three
eggs at a time. They are dull
white and about the size of golf
balls. Kookaburra families mostly
roost close together.*





Once the chicks are hatched, the family will share the tasks of feeding, teaching, and raising them.

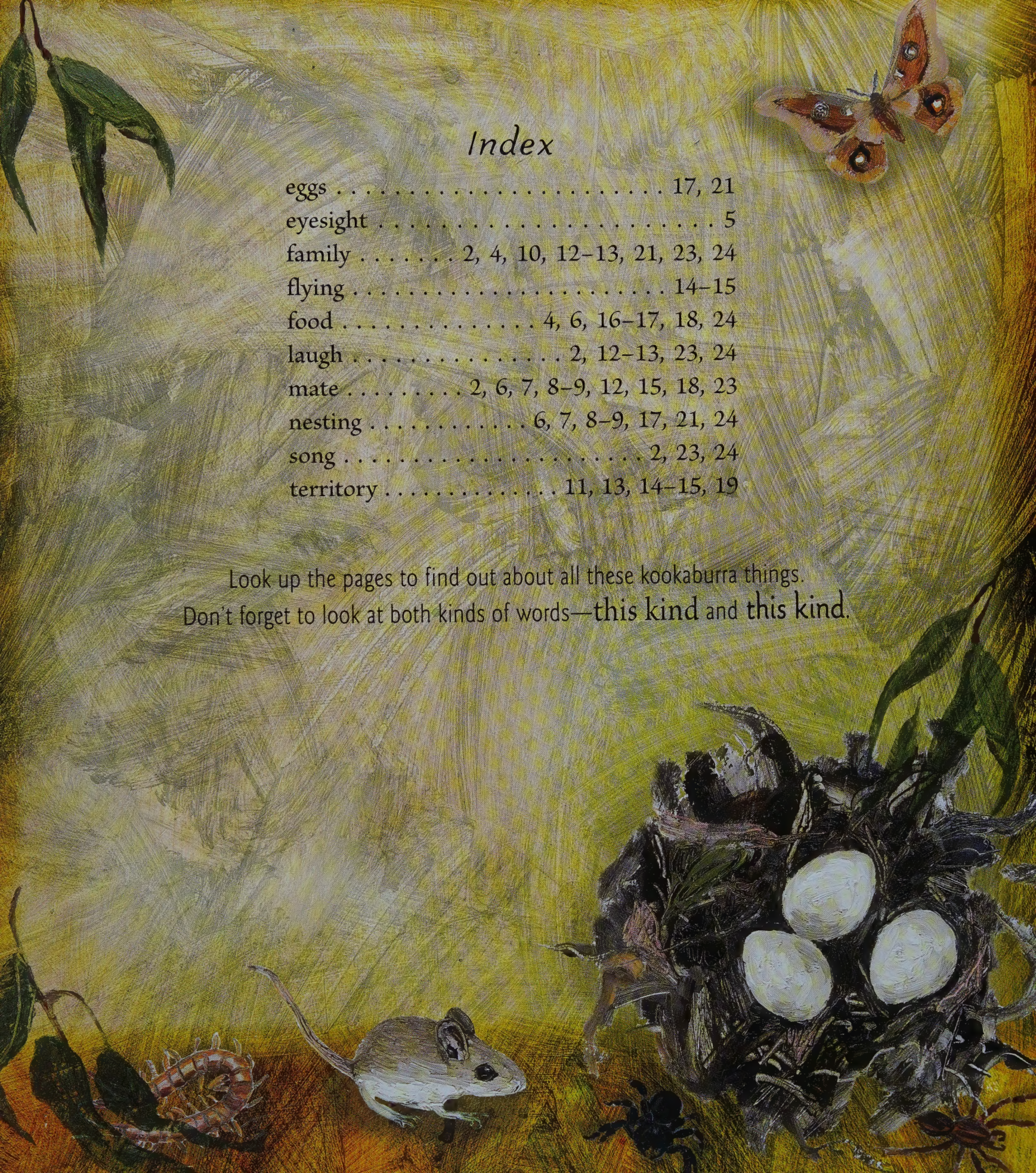
But not today. Today Kookaburra leads the night song.

This twilight, in a line on a limb
with her family, her mate,
Kookaburra laughs.

*Kook-kook-kook.
Kak-kak-kak.*

More About Kookaburras

The laughing kookaburra is the larger of the two Australian kookaburra species. Both are part of the kingfisher family. The name *kookaburra* is an adaptation of an Aboriginal word and describes their song. The laughing kookaburra is found widely throughout the eastern parts of Australia and in southern South Australia and Western Australia. They live where there is permanent access to water, food, and nesting sites. Their diet consists mostly of insects, spiders, and small reptiles. Laughing kookaburras have distinctive eye stripes, which can help them identify family members and intruders. Young kookaburras have a dark lower beak, which becomes lighter as they mature. They sometimes stay for a few years before leaving the family to find their own partners. Kookaburras mostly nest in tree hollows but have been known to nest in termite mounds and haystacks. They are adaptable and may live close to humans.



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Look up the pages to find out about all these kookaburra things.
Don't forget to look at both kinds of words—this kind and this kind.





In the crinkled shadows,
night dwellers yawn,
day creatures stretch,
and Kookaburra laughs.

*Kook-kook-kook
Kak-kak-kak*



US \$17.99 / \$23.99 CAN
ISBN 978-1-5362-1519-9



P9-DES-811